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Section Title(S): The Use Of Bena Kin Terms

Quite common now, as it is reported to have been in the past, is the practice of addressing older people and/or those thought especially worthy of respect as *mzee* (Sw., 'old man') which term is usually followed by the clan name in reference but not in address. In the past the Kibena term, *muvaaha* (which is an alternate term for 'father' among the Ulanga Bena) was used throughout Benaland in addressing unrelated people deemed worthy of respect, but it is only rarely encountered now.

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Generations. All consanguines and affines are divided into two groups according to generation. Own generation kin (including affines) and those of alternate generations are referred to as *vatani* (sing. *mutani*). Adjacent generations together with the third ascending and descending generations are referred to as *vakwi* (sing. *mukwi*).

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It is difficult and perhaps bootless to decide whether these two terms are Kibena only or both Swahili and Kibena. They are used in Swahili speech by Bena speakers wherein *vatani* and *vakwi* appear as *watani* and *wakwe* and *mutani* and *mukwi* are given as *mtani* and *mkwe* and these speakers say the terms are Swahili as well as Kibena. The same terms (especially *vatani* in one form or another) with similar meanings appear among a considerable number of Tanzanian groups⁵ among which Swahili is very widely spoken but whose

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local languages and kin terminologies⁶ are, or from existing evidence appear to be, closely related to Kibena and Bena terms. Thus, whether the similarities are due to the terms being present in common Swahili usage, because of linguistic connections among the local languages and between the latter and Swahili, or whether they may be attributed to general historical connections among the peoples cannot be established at present.

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Whatever their exact status from a linguistic point of view, *vatani* and *vakwi* and their singular forms are used only as terms of reference, although *mukwi* is a term in  45 its own right and is used reciprocally between ego and his wife's parents. The term *muva* mentioned above is appropriate for all *vakwi* and among the Highland Bena is used in addressing people who are believed to be *vakwi* but whose exact relationship to the speaker or his spouse is not known. Whether addressed as *muva* or not, anyone classed as a *mukwi* should be treated with respect and restraint especially as concerns matters relating to sexuality and bodily functions. Conversely, anyone classed with the *vatani* can be treated more freely and although the rather strong pressure for joking behavior noted for other groups toward people in this category (see footnote 5) is absent, there is sometimes horseplay and the exchange of mild teasing and 'friendly' insults among *vatani*. It is important to note, however, that both *vakwi* and *vatani* are categories of kin and affines and among the Bena these relationships do not exist between whole clans or other large groups as is the case for the Gogo, Luguru and others.

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⁵ See R. E. Moreau: 'The Joking Relation (*utani*) in Tanganyika', *Tanganyika Notes and Records*, xii, 1–10, 1941; T. V. Scrivenor: 'Some Notes on Utani, or the Vituperative Alliances Existing between Clans in the Masasi District', *Tanganyika Notes and Records*, iv, 72–4, 1937; E. Spies: 'Observations on Utani Customs among the Ngoni of Songea District', *Tanganyika Notes and Records*, xvi, 49–53; J. B. Christensen: '*Utani*': Joking, Sexual License and Social Obligations among the Luguru', *American Anthropologist*, lxxv, 1314–27, 1963; P. Rigby: 'Joking Relationships, Kin Categories, and Clanship among the Gogo', *Africa*, xxxviii, 133–55.

⁶ The extensive similarities and important differences among the kin terminologies of the Bena, Hehe, Sangu, Gogo and other Tanzanian groups could profitably be studied from linguistic, historical and sociological points of view. Rigby's (op. cit.) data shows that striking similarities exist between Gogo kin terms and Bena terms and W. Bryant Mumford ('The Hehe-Bena-Sangu Peoples of East Africa', *American Anthropologist*, 36, 203–22, 1934) suggests further parallels and differences with other tribes which will no doubt become clearer with the publication of works on the Hehe, now in press, by Edgar Winans and by Allison Redmayne. One of the main objectives of this article is to present the full list of Bena kin terms as a contribution to future comparative work.

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